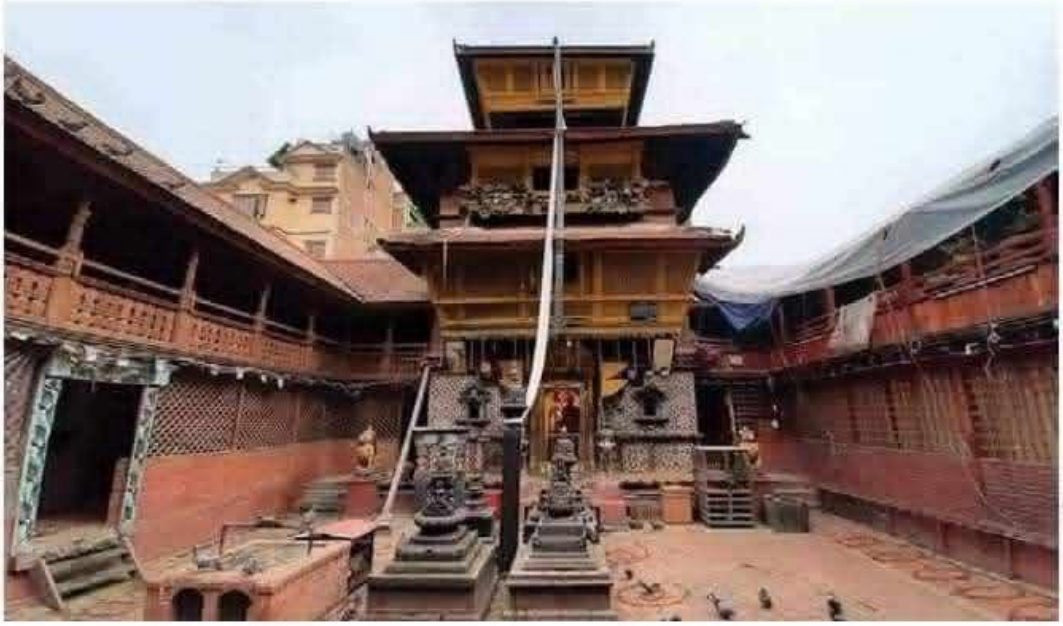
Heritage

Damodar Pradhan

Dharmadhatu Vihar, Thambahi, Vikramshila Mahavihar, Bhagwan Bahal



Vajrayana Buddhism

In ancient times, a Buddhist monastery called Dharmadhatu Vihar stood near the Samakhushi river, in what is now Samakhushi bazar. The temple suffered severe damage from the river, prompting its relocation to a higher elevation some distance away. Only a few remnants of the original structure remained at the old site. After the move, the monastery was renamed Thambahi, reflecting its new elevated location. The name Thambahi also carries connotations of prestige and antiquity, signifying one of the oldest and most important vihars in the area. The Swoyambhu Puran, a sacred text, mentions Sawaabhumi and Dharmadhatu vihar in its sixteenth chapter, further attesting to the monastery's ancient origins. However, precise details about its construction date and founder remain unknown. Neither the exact time of its establishment nor the identity of the individual or sangha responsible for its creation has been determined.

The famous Chinese traveler Hiuen Tsang (596-664 AD) documented the story of Simhala in his memoir "Si-yu-ki: Buddhist Record of the Western World," translated from Chinese to English by Samuel Beal in 1884. According to this account, Simhala (Sang-kia-lo), son of Simhaka (Sang-kia) from Jambudwipa, embarked on a sea voyage with 500 merchants. Their ship, driven by wind and waves, reached Ratnadwipa, the land of Rakshasa women. The Gunakaranbvyuha Sutra, also known as Simhalasarthavahodwora Prakarn, mentions in its sixteenth chapter

that during King Simhaketu's reign, a wealthy merchant named Simhaka and his son Simhala resided in Simhakalpa Nagar.

A legend tells of Simhala establishing the temple by donating all his possessions. The Pradhan family, who are Buddhists from the local area, serve as the temple's main patrons. They believe themselves to be descendants of Simhala Sarthabaha.

The oldest historical evidence of the new temple dates back to Atisa Dipankar Shrijana's visit to Nepal in 1041-1042 AD. During his year-long stay before traveling to Tibet, Atisa spent considerable time at Thambahi, where he composed two valuable works: Bodhi Patha Pradip (Lamp for the Path of Enlightenment)–66 stanzas in Sanskrit and Charya Sangraha Pradip. Atisa's contributions to Thambahi include: Constructing a white stupa in the inner courtyard after witnessing illuminated rays descending from the sky; Building five small stupas in northern Kathmandu, known as Panchmane; and Ordering Anantakirti, the king of Palpa, to assist in constructing Thambahi.

The oldest known golden manuscript from Nepal, Aryosnisavijaya-namadharani, dates back to 220 NS (1100 AD) and is in Purnaharsha Bajracharya's private collection. Thambahi possesses a remarkable golden manuscript entitled "Satasahrisika Prajnaparamita." It contains 100,000 verses written in real gold ink and is dated Nepal Sambat 344 (1224 AD), making it approximately 800 years old.

The Satasahrisika Prajnaparamita manuscript plays a crucial role in local festivals. During the Gunla festival (August/September), Bajracharya priests from four Kathmandu viharas recite it for eight days. At the conclusion of the Gaijatra festival, the Royal Kumari visits the temple to view the manuscript, and this is the only time when the general public can see this ancient text.

A stone inscription in the National Museum of Nepal documents the restoration of the temple in 408 NS (1288 AD) by Harisingh during King Parthivendra Malla's reign. Historical records indicate that various learned monks visited this vihar to study Buddhist philosophy, though much information about the temple's history remains unknown. In the early 13th century, Dharmashree Mitra, a scholar from Vikramshila Bihar at Nalanda University, came to study at the temple. The temple is known by two names: Bikramshil Mahavihar: Some scholars attribute this name to Dharmashree, and Bhagavan Bahal: A popular name derived from the main deity, Garud Bhagwan. Located in the northern part of Thamel, Kathmandu's primary tourist area, the temple stands as a significant landmark in Nepal's capital.

The Jataka Tales, narratives of Buddha's former incarnations, represent some of the oldest and most comprehensive folklore in Buddhist tradition. These stories offer valuable insights into the daily lives and thoughts of ancient people. Key points about the Jataka Tales are that it is comprised of 550 stories in Pali language, was orally transmitted to Ceylon (modern-day Sri Lanka) in the 3rd century BC, was introduced by Mahinda, who was either the son or brother of Emperor Ashoka, and a it marks the first introduction of Buddhism to the island. The Jataka Tales serve as an important historical and cultural record, blending religious teachings with popular storytelling traditions.

The famous Chinese traveler Faxian recorded 547 Jataka tales during his visit to India (399-411 AD). In 1896, Professor Fousboll of Copenhagen published 550 Tales in Pali, later translated into English under Edward Cowell's editorship. During King Simhaketu's reign, a wealthy merchant named Simhaka lived with his son Sinhala. Sinhala, leading 500 young merchants on a sea expedition for precious stones, earned the title Simhala Sarthabaha. Their ship, caught in a storm, wrecked near Tamradwip island. The group was rescued by rakshasas disguised as beautiful women. Avalokiteswora, the Divine Lord, warned Simhala of the danger and promised to appear as a white flying horse to help them escape. He cautioned Simhala not to look back and to chant the lord's name while crossing the ocean. Some manuscripts claim 250 people crossed safely whereas others state only Simhala reached the shore.

A rakshasa followed Simhala, claiming to be his wife with their child. The king, enchanted by her beauty, kept her in the palace. At night, she summoned other rakshasas, who devoured the royal family and staff. Simhala was then chosen as the community leader, earning the title Garud (Army Chief). He eventually became king, known as Garudjuju. After ascending to the throne, Simhala raised a powerful army and invaded Tamradwip. The rakshasas surrendered and agreed to leave the island, which was then colonized and renamed Simhaldweepa in his

honor. Upon his victorious return, a festival was organized where Simhala was welcomed with vermilion powder. His red image was called Chakandeo, meaning "universal king with unlimited boundary" (Chakravarti raja) and a three-tiered umbrella was used during the Chakandeo festival, symbolizing his status as a universal king. This celebration occurs a day after Holi, the festival of colors, as a joyous commemoration of victory.

Simhala gained popularity as a divine figure, known as Dipankar Garud Bhagwan. The reformed rakshasi, his former adversary, was also honored. She became known as Ajima, the protector Mother Goddess (Jatika Ajima) and was tasked with ensuring the community's security. In return, she requested that buildings in the area have no roof openings. This tradition persists, with the Pradhan family avoiding open rooftops in their residences. The name Jatika Ajima originates from her desire to eat before serving Dipankar Garud Bhagwan. "Jati" refers to the water drained before cooking rice, symbolizing her primacy in the ritual meal.

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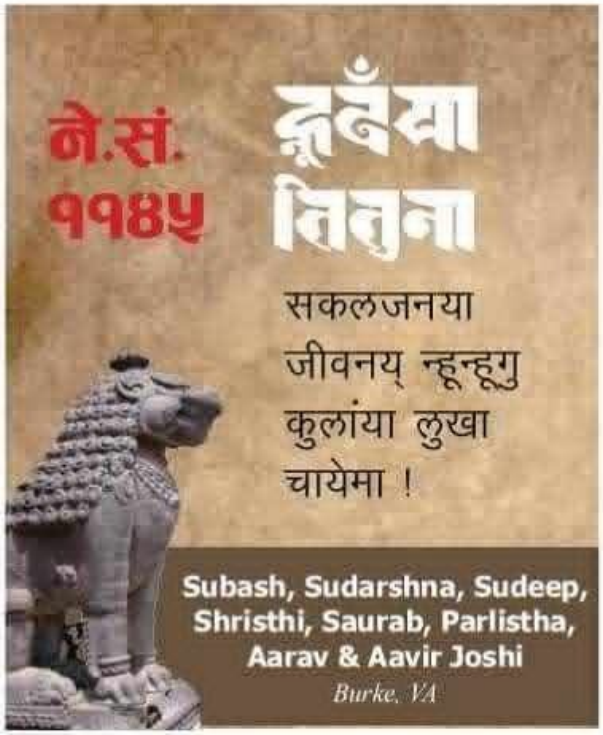
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